



THE TORTOISE Research and Captive Rearing Site was established at the sprawling Marine Corps Air Ground Combat Center in 2005.

Sheltering tortoises in the Mojave

Marine base houses young reptiles until they're hardy enough to withstand threats

BY ALEX WIGGLESWORTH

TWENTYNINE PALMS MARINE CORPS BASE, Calif. — The two tiny tortoises emerged from their burrows as soon as they detected Brian Henen's footsteps, eager for the handfuls of bok choy and snap peas that would soon be tossed their way.

It will be a few years before the tortoises, roughly the size of playing cards, have shells tough enough to avoid becoming prey for the ravens soaring above. So for now, they live with roughly 1,000 others of their species in a sheltered habitat ringed by barbed wire and draped in netting.

The elaborate setup on the



BRIAN HENEN, a civilian who heads the base's conservation branch, holds a desert tortoise, known as a "keystone species."

Marine Corps Air Ground Combat Center is designed to protect the tortoises not only from ravens, coyotes and other predators, but from rumbling tanks, live explosives and anything else that might put them in harm's way at the 1,189-square-mile Mojave Desert base.

"The desert tortoise is considered a keystone species, which means that they have a disproportionate effect on the entire ecosystem," says Henen, a civilian who heads the conservation branch of the base's Environmental Affairs Division.

The tortoises pockmark the desert floor with burrows that other animals use for shelter, and disperse the seeds of native plants [See Tortoises, A10]

Sleep deprivation fuels health and safety crisis in prisons

Rest may seem trivial, but an extreme lack of it adds to the system's problems, experts say.

BY KERI BLAKINGER AND SHANNON HEFFERNAN

Steven Backstrom was struggling to stay awake during his shift in the prison shoe factory. The machines could be dangerous if you weren't paying attention,

and he'd slept about 3 1/2 hours.

Activity at the Clements Unit, a state prison in Amarillo, Texas, was never-ending. Night after night, doors slammed and people yelled. Sometimes, staff delivered medications at 2 a.m. Many nights officers forced him to come to the front of his cell for a security check. The sleepless nights made him feel like a scum had settled over his brain.

But he didn't have the choice to skip work. The job

didn't pay, and if he didn't show up, he could be punished.

That morning, he pushed the wrong button on a machine, and the equipment, meant to mold the shape of the shoe, clamped down on Backstrom's right hand. The pain was excruciating. When he lifted his hand, his fingers were so badly mangled, he thought it looked like they were wobbling in the air. Backstrom later described the injuries in a handwritten grievance he sent to prison

officials in 2011: stitches and metal pins in his pinky and ring finger.

Backstrom sued the prison system over the accident the following year, blaming the injury on sleep deprivation, but a federal judge dismissed the suit. More than a decade later, Backstrom still cannot close his hand. He still can't get a decent night's sleep because relentless interruptions and noise remain a part of the nightly routine at the Clements Unit where he remains incarcerated.

The Marshall Project and Los Angeles Times have identified more than 30 lawsuits regarding sleep deprivation behind bars over the last three decades — including one that ended in a settlement requiring changes at a San Francisco jail three years ago. More than two dozen interviews with incarcerated people, guards and oversight officials from Georgia to Texas to California show that extreme lack [See Prisons, A5]

In Santa Cruz, 'Mother Nature holds the cards'

Waves have thrashed city in recent years, notably collapsing part of pier this week.

BY GRACE TOOHEY

To many locals, it feels like Santa Cruz's picturesque coast is being battered like never before.

Waves from strong winter storms and a pair of tsunamis have caused millions of dollars in damage to the wharf and marina area in recent years, including an onslaught of dangerous waves this week that washed almost 150 feet of the wharf out to sea.

A large section of the century-old wharf detached from the rest of the structure

amid turbulent swells Monday, sending three people — all of whom survived — into the sea, casting a bathroom to float miles south and leaving onlookers in shock.

"The wharf's been around for over 100 years, and this is the first time I can remember anything like this happening," said Gino Marini, co-owner of Marini's Candies, which has its flagship store not far from where part of the wharf broke off. His family's business has been on the wharf for 40 years, and although he remembers storms that caused significant damage — pilings cracking or boats crashing — there's never been a collapse this major.

The latest pummeling from the ocean worries officials and some locals, who [See Storms, A10]



A CHUNK of the Santa Cruz Wharf floats offshore after turbulent swells Monday. Local officials worry how common such strong waves may become in the area.

Newsom proposal is called risky by lawmaker

Fellow Democrat pushes to rescind call for constitutional convention on guns.

BY JULIA WICK

Last summer, Gov. Gavin Newsom made a splashy announcement on a nationally televised morning show.

As millions of Americans tuned in over their breakfast and coffee, California's Democratic governor said he was fed up with Congress' inability to pass gun safety laws and was taking matters into his own hands, calling for a new constitutional amendment to restrict firearms.

The proposal was more of a swashbuckling play for attention than a plan with any rational chance of success. The last — and only — time the states gathered for a constitutional convention was in 1787, when George Washington had yet to be elected as the United States' first president.

Still, California's Democratic lawmakers overwhelmingly approved Newsom's proposal, and formally called for a convention to amend the Constitution to ban the sale of assault weapons, require universal background checks on gun purchases and raise the minimum age to buy a firearm from 18 to 21.

But a handful of Democrats did not go along with the plan. A progressive senator from San Francisco was the most vocal critic, arguing that a constitutional convention could wind up empowering a conservative agenda. And now, with the country in flux and a former president known for defying the laws of political gravity and pulverizing long-standing norms soon to be sworn back into office, he's launched a new push to blunt Newsom's flashy maneuver and rescind California's call to amend the Constitution.

"There is no way that I want California to accidentally help these extremists trigger a constitutional convention where they, you know, rewrite the Constitution to restrict voting rights, to eliminate reproductive [See Convention, A6]

Homelessness is up 18% in U.S.

The increase, officials say, is driven by a lack of affordable housing, natural disasters and migration. **NATION, A4**

Insurance's high cost for renters

It's harder to obtain and more expensive as insurers pull back from homeowners market. **BUSINESS, A7**

Dodgers re-sign popular player

Clutch power hitter Teoscar Hernández reaches a three-year, \$66-million deal with the team. **SPORTS, B12**

Weather

Fog, then some sun. L.A. Basin: 64/48. **B8**

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